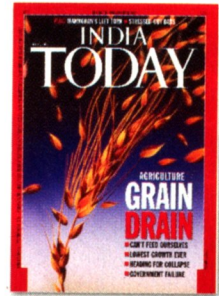


HEMANT CHAWLA



"Grain Drain",
June 11, 2007

"The Centre should take radical steps to boost agricultural production. Innovation and diversification will make the farm sector profitable."

V.G. PRAKASH, *Bangalore*

Crop Circles

The Government should ban the use of agricultural land for non-agricultural purposes. Barren land that is not used for agriculture should be given to industries ("Grain Drain", June 11). Corporate farming should be allowed so that banks come forward to finance agriculture.

MAN MOHAN BHATIA, *Delhi*

India seems so overwhelmed with its IT-driven economic boom that it is totally neglecting agriculture, which is still the main sector of the Indian economy. It is shameful that agricultural growth has plunged to an all-time low and the Government is doing nothing to salvage the sector.

K. CHIDANAND KUMAR,
Bangalore

The cover story gives a very shocking picture.

While on the surface things seem hunky-dory, the rates of growth of agriculture in the last decade have been poor and a major cause of rural distress. Productivity is secondary, the Centre should first take steps to give benefits to farmers.

MIRLE S. SITARAM, *Bangalore*

It's disheartening to see that you have used a blurb that says: "Can't Feed Ourselves". This is both false and mischievous. It's unfair to say that imports are not rising because of lack of domestic production. It is, in fact, because of agri-business pressure through the World Bank, World Trade Organisation and now the US-India agricultural agreement.

VANDANA SHIVA, *Delhi*

Your cover story paints a dismal picture of the farm sector. How can you say that more than 40 per cent of the farmers want to opt out of the profession?

Instead of harping on the negatives, you could have highlighted the positives. The Rs 25,000-crore package announced by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh will definitely bring about a change in the farm sector.

ONKAR CHOPRA, *Delhi*

The Centre should arrange for ways to finance farmers to rid them of the malaise of age-old money-lenders. Irrigation should be at the doorstep and proper electricity and storage facility should be provided to attract the younger generation into the sector.

TRISHEET CHATTERJEE, *Delhi*

Agriculture is a slow-income yielding sector. However, with vast land area and manpower, India can still produce surplus products for exports too.

CHETAN PRABHAKAR, *Gurgaon*

Sharad Pawar's interview is lacklustre and unsatisfactory. As the Union

minister for food and agriculture, he should own up responsibility for the deterioration of the farm sector. How can he attribute the present dismal picture in agriculture to lack of long-term loan from financial institutions? Nationalised banks have been forced to write off several crores of rupees because loans were not being regularly repaid.

DEBASISH CHATTERJEE, *Kolkata*

Single Category

The recent Meena-Gujjar caste war on reservation calls for a complete overhaul of the divide-and-rule policy of political parties ("Caste in Conflict", June 11). For proper implementation of quota, political parties should merge SC, ST and OBC into one single category.

MADHU AGRAWAL, *Delhi*

Tollywood Turnaround

It's heartening to read that Bengali films have finally